Laptop care and travel guidelines

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Summary

This article provides practical guidance for Acme Global employees on preparing, using, and securing company-issued laptops while traveling. It covers pre-travel checks, safe handling on the road, and post-trip verification steps that users can perform themselves, as well as the specific actions the Desktop Support team should take when a travel-related issue is reported.

Symptoms

- Laptop fails to boot or shows a BitLocker recovery screen after travel
- Unable to connect to ACME-Corp Wi-Fi or VPN GlobalProtect
- Physical damage signs such as cracked screen, loose hinges, or liquid spillage
- Missing or expired device certificate causing VPN authentication failure

Common causes

- Improper shutdown or power loss leading to BitLocker recovery mode
- Exposure to extreme temperatures, humidity, or physical shocks during transit
- Using unsecured public networks without VPN, risking credential exposure
- Failing to renew or backup the machine certificate before travel

Pre-travel preparation

Before you leave the office, verify that your laptop is fully updated and encrypted. Check that BitLocker (Windows) or FileVault (macOS) is active and that the recovery key is backed up in Intune. Ensure the latest Windows security patches (released on Patch Tuesday) are installed, or that macOS is up to date via Software Update. Confirm that your GlobalProtect machine certificate is valid (certificates renew yearly) and that you have a copy of the certificate or know how to re-enroll if needed. Finally, pack the laptop in a padded sleeve, keep the charger and any adapters in a separate compartment, and label the bag with your name and employee ID.

1. 1. Open the Company Portal app and verify that the device shows "Compliant".
2. 2. For Windows: run `manage-bde -status` in an elevated PowerShell prompt to confirm BitLocker protection and note the recovery key ID.
3. 3. For macOS: open System Settings -> Privacy & Security -> FileVault and ensure it is turned on; note the recovery key stored in Intune.
4. 4. Connect to VPN (vpn.acme.example) and confirm the connection succeeds; if prompted, renew the certificate via the Self-Service Portal.
5. 5. Shut down the laptop completely (do not use Sleep or Hibernate) before packing.

During travel - handling and connectivity

While on the move, treat the laptop as a valuable asset. Keep it within sight at all times and avoid leaving it unattended in public areas. Use the ACME-Corp Wi-Fi network when available; it uses 802.1X with machine certificates for secure authentication. If you must use a public hotspot, always connect to the GlobalProtect VPN first to encrypt traffic. Avoid exposing the device to direct sunlight, extreme cold, or moisture-store it in the insulated sleeve of your bag and allow it to acclimate to room temperature before powering on after a long flight. If you notice any unusual noises, overheating, or a warning light, power off the device immediately and contact the Service Desk.

Post-travel verification

Once you return to an Acme office or a trusted network, run a quick health check to ensure the laptop is still compliant and ready for work. Re-connect to the ACME-Corp Wi-Fi to verify that the machine certificate is still valid and that you receive an IP address without errors. Launch the Company Portal and confirm that compliance status remains "Compliant". Check for any pending Windows updates or macOS upgrades and install them according to the patch

schedule. Finally, run a brief antivirus scan using Microsoft Defender for Endpoint (or the built-in macOS protection) to rule out any threats picked up while traveling.

1. 1. Log in with your Entra ID credentials; if you see a BitLocker recovery prompt, retrieve the recovery key from Intune and enter it.
2. 2. Open Settings -> Accounts -> Access work or school and verify that the device is joined to Azure AD.
3. 3. Run `winver` (Windows) or ? -> About This Mac (macOS) to confirm the OS version is current.
4. 4. In the Company Portal, select "Device compliance" and initiate a sync if needed.
5. 5. If any issue persists, create a ticket in the IT self-service portal or call extension 4357.

Service Desk Agent Procedure

When a user reports a travel-related laptop issue, follow the Desktop Support workflow to diagnose and resolve the problem efficiently. Begin by verifying the user's identity and collecting essential details: device model, serial number, OS version, and a clear description of the symptom (e.g., BitLocker recovery screen, VPN failure, physical damage). Check Intune for the device's compliance status, BitLocker/FileVault state, and certificate validity. If the device is non-compliant, guide the user through remediation steps or schedule a remote wipe/re-enroll as appropriate. For hardware damage, arrange a depot swap or on-site repair according to the hardware warranty process. Document all actions in the ticket and provide the user with a confirmation email summarizing the resolution and any follow-up actions required.

1. 1. Greet the user and confirm their name, employee ID, and contact details.
2. 2. Ask for the laptop's service tag or serial number and locate the device in Intune.
3. 3. Review the device compliance page: note BitLocker/FileVault status, last sync time, and any non-compliant flags.
4. 4. If the user reports a boot error, retrieve the BitLocker recovery key from Intune and provide it securely.
5. 5. For VPN/Wi-Fi issues, verify the machine certificate expiry date; if expired, initiate a certificate renewal via the Self-Service Portal or issue a temporary certificate.
6. 6. For physical damage, create a hardware service request and advise the user to bring the device to the nearest Desktop Support drop-off point or arrange a courier pickup.
7. 7. After resolution, close the ticket with a summary of steps taken and remind the user of the travel-care best practices.

When to escalate

If the issue cannot be resolved within the Desktop Support SLA (P2 High 8?h) - for example, persistent BitLocker lockout requiring key recovery beyond standard procedures, widespread certificate expiration affecting multiple devices, or confirmed hardware failure needing depot repair - escalate to the Identity & Access Management team for certificate/key problems or to the Hardware Vendor Support liaison for warranty repairs. Include the device's serial number, Intune compliance report, error messages, and any troubleshooting steps already performed.

Keywords: laptop travel, BitLocker recovery, FileVault, GlobalProtect VPN, machine certificate, Intune compliance, secure packing, laptop care, tragging guidelines, Desktop Support procedure